THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

GENERAL MEETING

The Paris Branch General Meeting was held on Tuesday 21st June, 2016 at 19h00.

The Chairman, Mr. R. Thorn, welcomed all present and said this was the first such Paris Branch General Meeting in living memory, other than the Annual General Meetings held each November. We are required by London, as laid down in the Membership Handbook, to hold General Meetings at least quarterly. In the past we have informed our members of items of interest in our bi-monthly newsletters.

Members present were : Mesdames Clopet, Corrigan, Hadley, Morris and Warby and Messrs. Bean, Gould, Huggins, Ignatovitch, Plunkett, Scott, Sechet and Yates.

The Chairman asked all present to stand for the Exhortation and Silent Tribute.

Chairman's Report : The Chairman reported he had attended The Royal British Legion Annual Conference in Eastbourne, UK. The Chairman said that our relationship with London was calm and that after last summers fiasco we were back on track in building bridges with London over the Comradeship Project which caused so many problems with our Membership. We were told we were an argumentative branch, but in all honesty we were holding out for the best interest of our Members. At the National Conference many questions were asked by delegates from the floor about the Comradeship Project and why it was a half-baked scheme. There were many questions and answers from which the RBL Management clearly understood that the Membership were not happy with decisions taken without adequately consulting the Members beforehand. The RBL National Chairman said that this was not a perfect project and that people do not like change. The floor informed the Conference that this was an ill conceived and ill executed project. Our Chairman reported that two questions stood out in his mind. They were : i) "was Due Diligence carried out on Novacroft the company given the task to take on our Membership renewals", to which the answer was "NO" and ii) the other question raised was "Who gave authority to move membership data to Novacroft, surely infringing thereby the Date Protection legislation", to which the answer was "this was an usual practice". Remarks from the floor of Conference ranged from "Rubbish to Not Acceptable". The Chairman said that the RBL Management got a hostile reception.

Future Events : The Chairman informed the meeting that our Annual Ceremony of Rekindling the Flamme at the Arc de Triomphe would be held on Thursday 4th August. This year it is the turn of the Canadian Ambassador or his representative to lay the wreath. We await their reply.

The Pedal to Paris would be leaving UK on 1st September and arriving in Paris on 4th September. There will be a wreath laying ceremony at 16h00 at the Arc de Triomphe.

Somme Battlefield Visit : This visit will take place in September (15/16/17th). The group will also take part in a National Ceremony at the Thiepval Memorial organised by TRBL London.

The Annual Coffee Morning to launch the Poppy Appeal will be held at the Ambassador's Residence on Friday 4th November 10h30 – 12h00. Information will be sent out in the Newsletter at the rentree.

The Chairman invited Mr. Peter Huggins to speak to the meeting. Mr. Huggins said he would soon be moving to Germany. He had sorted out some books and had a series of books by Hammerton on World War 2 which contained many documents and records of events during the Second World War in digestible form. Mr. Huggins said he would like to give them to the Legion and said we could either keep the 9 volumes in the Clubhouse or auction them off to raise money for our Funds. The Chairman thanked Mr. Huggins and wished him well in his move to Germany.

The Chairman invited Mr. Philip Sechet to address the meeting. Mr. Sechet said he had addressed the Committee in April outlining his hope of organising a joint venture with TRBL and his Association Le Souvenir Français of which he is President of the Neuilly sur Seine Branch. Mr. Sechet said the idea was to bring together the British, Commonwealth, U.S., and French Armies to commemorate the end of World War One. V.I.P's from Britain, the Commonwealth and France would be at the event. Mr. Sechet said the Sovenir Français is waiting to get the green light from the French to organise this project, then meetings could begin to decide where best to hold the event. It

was intended as a grass-roots veterans' event rather than an official, governmental one. The event would be in the form of a Ceremony and Cocktail. Mr. Sechet said he would inform the Chairman and Committee when he had a suitable answer. The Chairman thanked Mr. Sechet and said he would await any further news of the project.

Hon. Secretary's Report : The Secretary said she had some Poppy Pins to commemorate the 100 years of the Battle of the Somme. There are two types of pin one with just the Poppy and the other with the Poppy and Bleuet. The cost of these was €3 each or €5 for two pins.

Hon. Treasurer's Report : In the absence of the Treasurer, it was reported that the General Fund (Admin) stood at €1,394.72, the Poppy Appeal Account stood at €26,484.82 and the Deposit Account stood at €34,218.82. This report had been proposed by Mr. Plunkett and seconded by Mrs. Hadley. **Carried**

Association de Veterans Brittanique Bar Report : The Chairman asked Mr. Gould if he would like to speak on about the AdVB. Mr. Gould started by explaining that in the UK it was normal in some areas to have an RBL Club with bar. Unfortunately those branches overseas were not allowed to trade in alcohol. So to get around this an Association 1901 had been formed independent of the RBL to run the bar. All RBL Paris Branch members are invited to join. Mr. Gould said he would present his first AGM after our Branch AGM in November.

Welfare Report : Mr. Bean reported that Welfare was very quiet at the moment as there are not many retired British people living in the Paris area. However, we were always ready to assist any Ex-Service Person and or their families who found themselves in need of financial aid.

The Chairman invited Mrs. Hadley to talk about the School Project? Mrs. Hadley informed the meeting that she had attended some Schools/Lycees with British Sections to talk about the Poppies and why we have them. With Mr. Thorn and Mr. Huggins she went to Lycee Pasteur to see their exhibition. With Mr. Thorn, they attended a ceremony at Ranville with that school. Mrs. Hadley said she had a presentation on her computer to show anyone interested in looking at the work. There were 10 schools who had contributed work to the Project and with Messrs. Huggins and Thorn they had judged that Lycee Pasteur were worthy winners of an RBL Trophy. All those pupils who had taken part were presented with a Certificate (160 in total).

There being no further business the meeting was closed at 20h25.